

The Practitioner's Pharmacy

The actives that work, the conflicts that harm, and the caution deeper skin deserves

Learning Objectives

- Identify the core actives — niacinamide, vitamin C, BHA/AHA, retinoids, SPF — and their function
- Recognise which actives conflict and must never be layered on the same night
- Apply the deep-skin caution required before exfoliating or extracting on Fitzpatrick IV–VI
- Explain, honestly, why price and efficacy are not the same measurement

Ingredients, not brands

A practitioner who thinks in brand names has learned marketing, not skin. A practitioner who thinks in ingredients can build an effective routine anywhere, in any price bracket. This module trains the second kind of practitioner.

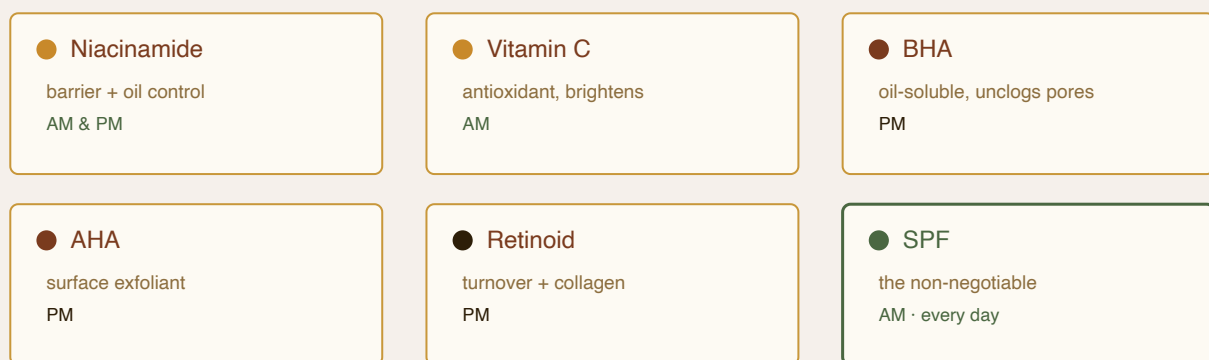
Luxury is knowledge, not price. Remember this phrase. You will need it again in Module Thirteen, and for the whole of your career.

The core actives, plainly explained

- **Niacinamide (vitamin B3).** Calms inflammation, strengthens the barrier, regulates oil, gently fades pigmentation. Often the ideal first active for sensitised or acne-prone skin.
- **Vitamin C.** A powerful antioxidant, defending against environmental damage while brightening tone. Best used in the morning, beneath sunscreen.
- **BHA (salicylic acid).** Oil-soluble, travels into the pore itself — the tool of choice for blackheads and mild-to-moderate acne.

- **AHAs (glycolic, lactic acid).** Water-soluble surface exfoliants, dissolving bonds between dead cells.
- **Retinoids.** Derived from vitamin A; accelerate cell turnover, boost collagen, improve fine lines and pigmentation.
- **SPF.** The most important product in this list — you will learn precisely why in Module Seven.

◆ Figure 4.1 · The Core Actives



The six core actives, each with its function and its ideal time of use.

The conflicts — what must never share a night

- **Retinoid + BHA/AHA, same night — avoid.** Both increase turnover and sensitivity; irritation compounds. Alternate nights instead.
- **Retinoid + Vitamin C, same application — generally avoid.** Different pH requirements reduce stability. Separate to AM (vitamin C) and PM (retinoid).
- **Multiple strong exfoliants, same routine — avoid.** Stacking a scrub, BHA, and AHA damages the barrier faster than it improves results.

The governing principle: **introduce one active at a time, watch the skin's response, and never mistake more for better.**

The deep-skin caution

Deeper skin tones (Fitzpatrick IV–VI) carry a heightened risk of PIH and keloid scarring from any inflammation or injury. Over-aggressive exfoliation, forceful extraction, or introducing

potent actives too quickly on deeper skin risks *creating* the very pigmentation problem you were treating. Always start actives gradually, favour gentler exfoliation, and never force an extraction. This caution returns concretely in Module Eleven.



The Origin BubbleAncient Greece · Willow bark · Hippocrates

The Bitter Bark of the Riverbank

Along the riverbanks of ancient Greece grew the willow, its bark bitter and grey. Around 400 BCE, the physician Hippocrates recorded that a tea brewed from willow leaves and bark eased pain and reduced fever. Centuries earlier still, the Egyptians had inscribed something similar on papyrus.

No one in that riverside clinic knew why it worked. There was no chemistry to explain it, only the accumulated evidence of patient after patient finding relief.

It would take until the nineteenth century for chemists to finally isolate the compound responsible — *salicin* — and refine it into salicylic acid, and later into aspirin itself.

The science

Salicylic acid, first identified in willow bark, is oil-soluble and anti-inflammatory — the exact BHA you will reach for constantly, still doing what Hippocrates' patients felt beside the river.

Why this belongs here: Every time you recommend a BHA, you extend a line of observation that began on a Greek riverbank.

Key Terms

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1

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Practical Activity · Priya's Actives

Choose two or three actives best suited to Priya's case: jawline acne, PIH, and a tight, dull barrier on Fitzpatrick V skin. Explain why, how you would introduce them gradually, and which nights they must never share. **You are laying the foundation for her full routine in Module Thirteen.**